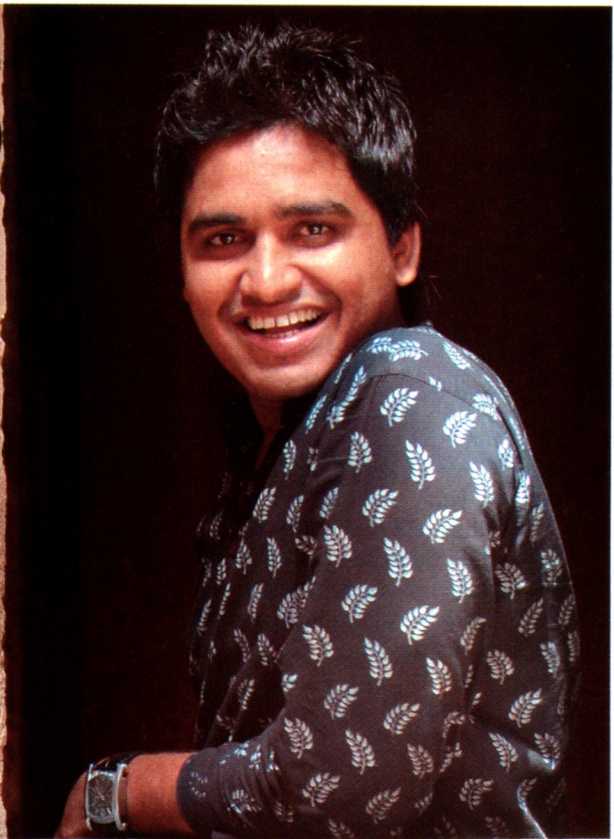


BACK TO

As corporates pump in mega bucks and new-age directors introduce fresh ideas to the ever-growing Indian entertainment industry, Marathi films are now ready for the spotlight

THE ROOTS



MANDAR DEODHAR

■ By Aditi Pai

Years after its Marathi film shows ran to empty houses, Chitra Cinema in downtown Dadar asked Zee Talkies for extra prints of *Saade Maade Teen*. The biggest blockbuster in the history of Marathi cinema—by two 30-year-old debutant directors Ankush Chaudhari and Sachit Patil—grossed over Rs 4.5 crore within the first six weeks of release in November last year and is still going strong. Made at a cost of Rs 1.25 crore, the hilarious take on the bonding among three brothers is a rip-off of the Bollywood classic *Chalti Ka Naam Gaadi*. “The film changed the mindset of viewers and producers, who realised that Marathi movies can be entertaining,” says Nitin Vaidya, director of Zee Regionals, which

produced the film.

The boom time continues this year, with distributors raking in big bucks and producers scrambling for a piece of the Marathi films’ pie. Reliance Entertainment, Zee Talkies and Mukta Arts are planning an investment of Rs 50 crore in the Marathi industry over the next three years. Apart from *Sanai Choughade* and *Prarambh*, which are lined up for release, Mukta Arts is aiming for 10 more movies this year, at a budget of about Rs 1 crore each. “Apart from promoting new scripts, we want to invest in marketing and plan wider releases,” says Ravi Gupta, CEO of Mukta Arts.

MANGESH HADALE,
27, DIRECTOR
His movie *Tingya*
won awards at
the international
film festivals
in Mumbai
and Pune

Sanai Choughade is co-produced by actor Shreyas Talpade that promises to have oodles of comedy, emotion and drama. “I wanted to give back something to my language. If my goodwill in the glamour world creates a buzz and ensures a good opening

for the film, it will be my contribution to the Marathi film industry,” says Talpade, 32, who will be seen in a romantic cameo in the film. Zee’s plans include a dozen films with a budget of not less than Rs 1.5 crore each. Their second film, *De Dhakka*, a tale of a family’s journey from Kolhapur to Mumbai, hit the theatres in mid-May and is currently running to packed